



WORLD CUP 2026 PREDICTOR



Can a Machine Learning model
out-predict a football fan?

A live, end-to-end Data Science project

Predictions published BEFORE every match —
and tracked publicly, hits and misses alike.

Adrián Blanco

Junior Data Scientist

THE IDEA

An honest forecaster, in public.

Most prediction posts appear AFTER the match.
This one commits before kickoff — every time.

- Before**

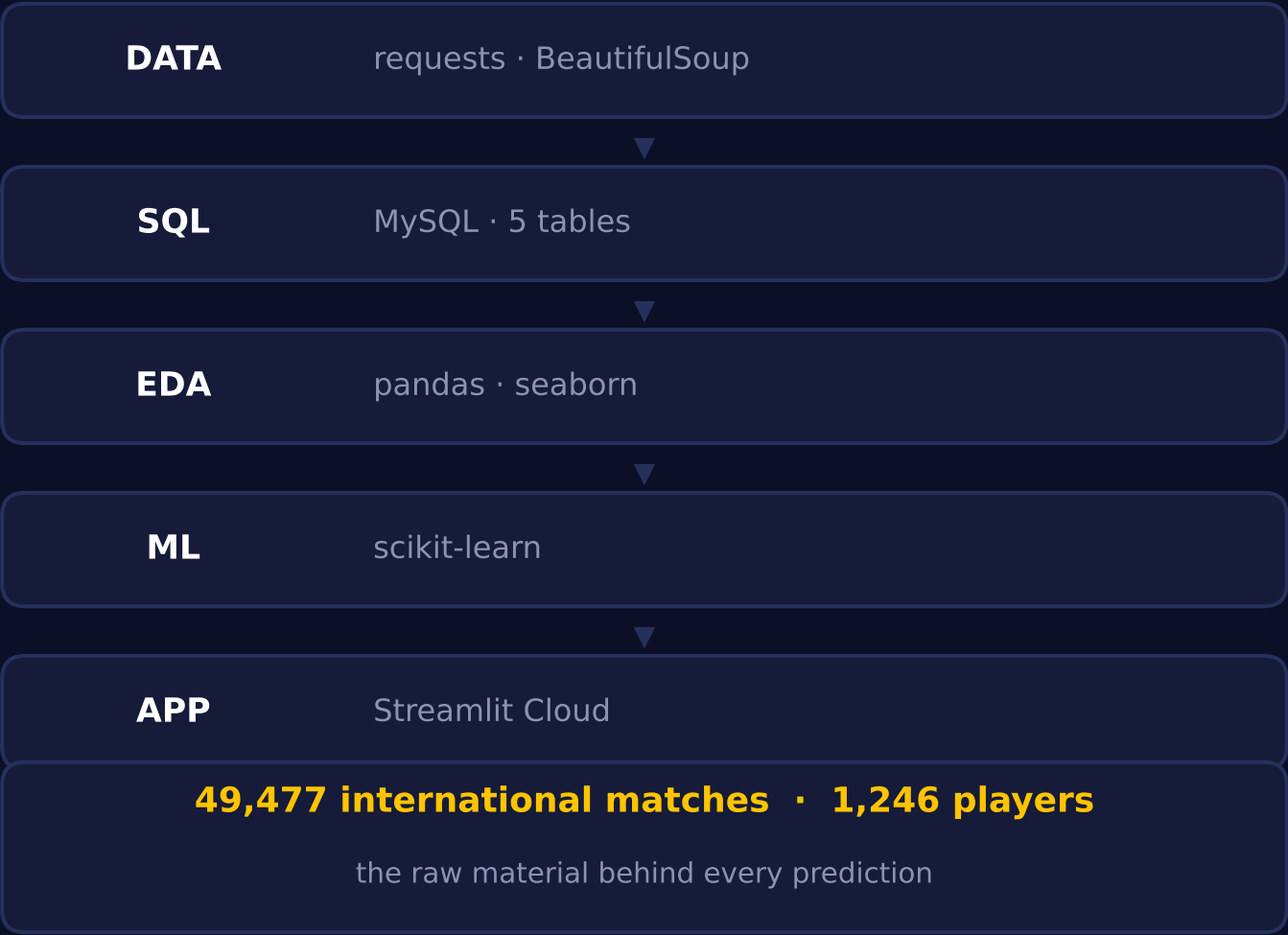
Probabilities + an exact-score guess published ahead of each matchday.
- During**

A live dashboard updates automatically after every result.
- After**

Performance measured with the right metric — no cherry-picking.

THE PIPELINE

A full DS pipeline,
end to end.



THE MODELS

Four models, one ensemble.

Elo ratings

Built from scratch over 49k matches. Updates with every result — the model keeps learning.

Random Forest

Match outcome (win / draw / win), using Elo as a live feature.

Poisson

Exact-score model — goals from the Elo gap.

Monte Carlo

10,000 simulations of the tournament to get champion odds.

+ an *RF·Poisson* ensemble that wins on RPS

MEASURED HONESTLY

Accuracy lies. So I used RPS.

For a probabilistic forecaster of ordered outcomes, accuracy is the wrong yardstick. The Ranked Probability Score (RPS) is the standard metric.

0.188

RPS (≈ 0.20 is on par)

0.031

calibration error (ECE)

Well-calibrated: when the model says 70%,
it happens about 70% of the time.

RESULTS · GROUP STAGE

**72 matches.
The warm-up.**

53%

outcomes correct

14

exact scores nailed

The exact-score model hit 19% of scorelines —
well above the ~11% of world-class models.

The accuracy trap

Raw accuracy looked noisy over a small sample,
but RPS stayed right on its historical value.
The model behaved exactly as expected.

RESULTS · KNOCKOUTS

Where it got serious.

25/31

ties called right

81%

knockout accuracy

And where it missed, it missed for the one reason nobody can beat:

4 of the misses were penalty shootouts

A shootout is a coin flip. The model treats it as ~50/50 instead of pretending to know — because faking it would be dishonest.

THE HEADLINE

It called the champion.



SPAIN

WORLD CHAMPIONS

Before the final, the model's odds:

52%

VS

48%

Spain

Argentina

Final: Spain 1 - 0 Argentina (a.e.t.)

The dream final it had flagged since the round of 32.

THE FULL PICTURE

The whole
tournament.

103

matches predicted

60%

overall accuracy

18

exact scores



champion called

A model that stayed honest all tournament —
and still got the big one right.

Let's talk.

Open to Junior Data Scientist roles

Built with

Python · pandas · scikit-learn · MySQL

Streamlit · matplotlib · soccerdata

See it live

predictor-worldcup2026.streamlit.app

Code

github.com/AdriBlanco0/worldcup2026-predictor

Adrián Blanco

linkedin.com/in/adrianblancoajenjo

